



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of Rochester
School Website: <https://www.chestertonacademyofrochester.org/>

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Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy Rochester, NY 14617 presents a robust, Catholic, classical high-school model that aligns strongly with core classical education criteria. Public-facing materials emphasize a Catholic, formation-focused mission; a curriculum centered on liberal arts, liturgical life, and a humanities-forward progression; a pedagogy that includes Socratic discussion and rhetoric; a faculty described as a living curriculum who take formal vows to uphold magisterial teaching; and an active partner relationship with families and the broader school community. Taken together, these elements yield an overall CLASSICAL assessment, with the most explicit strengths in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, Purpose and Goal, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents & Community. The Curriculum category shows substantial classical substance but lacks explicit public statements about some canonical phrases (e.g., direct "Great Books" language) that would push it toward a firmer "CLASSICAL" label in every detail; as such Element 3 is judged SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, while the other categories meet or exceed classical expectations. The aggregate classification is CLASSICAL.

Key strengths include: explicit Catholic identity and liturgical practice (Mass daily, daily prayer, Liturgy of the Hours), a mission framed around formation and virtue, a history/history-philosophy-theology-languages-heavy curriculum with readings of classic authors, a Socratic method emphasis in upper-level humanities, and a faithful-faculty model including the Magisterium oath. The school also foregrounds parental partnership, open houses, shadow days, and annual events consistent with classical education's emphasis on family involvement.

Evidence sources include direct statements from Chesterton Academy Rochester's site (Our Mission and Model, Catholic Identity, Spiritual Life, course and humanities offerings, faculty, house system, liturgy, and parental engagement) as well as a publicly accessible summary of the classical-education lexicon from the Six Essential Elements materials (Positive Keywords and formation-focused indicators). See citations to the Chesterton Academy Rochester site and to the Six Essential Elements documents for keyword frameworks.

- Our Mission and Model: "The mission of Chesterton Academy of Rochester (grades 9–12) is to partner with parents to raise a generation of joyful leaders and saints educated in the classical liberal arts tradition and the truths of the Catholic faith."
- Catholic Identity and Integrated Theology across disciplines: "At Chesterton Academy, everything revolves around Jesus Christ and the Catholic faith. All classes point to the Incarnation as the central event in human history, so students won't just learn about their faith in one class, but across the disciplines. Students read and discuss the Bible, the Catechism of the Catholic Church, and papal documents."
- Liturgical life and daily prayer: "We begin each day with the Liturgy of the Hours and each class with prayer."
- Mass daily and spiritual formation: "Mass every school day" and a spiritual formation framework around a culture of life.
- Classical curriculum orientation: explicit reference to being a "classical high school, grounded in the Catholic faith," and a humanities-focused program that integrates literature, history, philosophy, theology, and languages.

- Public-facing faculty and governance posture: references to faithful faculty, oath of fidelity to magisterium, and a house-based student-life structure.
- Course and humanities program structure (Literature, History, Philosophy, Theology, languages, arts): detailed course strands and sequencing that foreground classical disciplines.
- Parental partnership and open-house culture: invitation to visit, shadow days, and homeschool-family alignment materials.

Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school's mission foregrounds Catholic faith as central to formation: "partner with parents to raise a generation of joyful leaders and saints educated in the classical liberal arts tradition and the truths of the Catholic faith." - Catholic identity is explicitly highlighted: "Everything revolves around Jesus Christ and the Catholic faith. All classes point to the Incarnation as the central event in human history, so students won't just learn about their faith in one class, but across the disciplines." - Daily liturgical life and prayer: "We begin each day with the Liturgy of the Hours and each class with prayer." - The spiritual formation pillar (intellect, character formation, spirituality) reinforces transcendent aims and moral formation.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: Catholic, faith, Incarnation, Liturgy, prayer, Magisterium, Mass, liturgy, catechism, papal documents, sacred tradition, virtue, virtue formation, culture of life, God, Gospel, spiritual formation. These terms map directly to the Positive Keywords framework for religious/metaphysical foundations (theology, liturgical life, sacred tradition, moral formation, transcendence). The materials frequently use explicit religious language (Catholic identity, Mass, Liturgy of the Hours).

- Negative keywords: None evident (no explicit secular or anti-religious rhetoric seen in public materials).

Frequency/Proportion (qualitative to quantitative translation) - Positive keywords: high density (multiple explicit mentions of Catholic faith, Mass, liturgy, theology, catechism, Magisterium, etc.). Negative keywords: none identified in public materials.

Why this rating - The school clearly situates religious-metaphysical foundations as foundational to its mission, culture, and daily practice, aligning with the classical ideal of transcendental moral realism and liturgical/-community practices. The explicit integration of Catholic theology across disciplines and the communal, liturgical life strongly anchors this category in CLASSICAL territory.

Cited examples anchor the assessment: mission text, Catholic-identity statements, liturgy/prayer practices. See citations above.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes formation and human flourishing over mere information: "joyful leaders and saints educated in the classical liberal arts tradition and the truths of the Catholic faith" and "three pillars of formation: Intellect, Character Formation, and Spirituality." - The language foregrounds virtue formation and human excellence rather than mere job preparation: "formation of character," "virtue," "culture of life," and "leadership for service." - The vows and structure emphasize living pedagogy aligned to formation rather than just content delivery. - The Vision and Model frame the school as a classical liberal-arts institution grounded in truth, goodness, and beauty.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: formation, virtue, character, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, culture of life, virtuous, imitation of the good, spiritual formation, freedom of mind, leadership, joy, saints. The public materials repeatedly emphasize formation and virtue as core goals.

- Negative keywords: None evident.

Frequency/Proportion - Positive keyword density is high (formation, virtue, character, truth/beauty, culture of life, etc.). No explicit negative indicators.

Why this rating - The school's stated purpose centers on formation, virtue, and ultimate human flourishing rather than vocational training or rote information, aligning with CLASSICAL criteria for the second category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Core orientation to liberal arts is explicit: “classical high school... grounded in the Catholic faith,” and the Humanities Program lists Grade 9–12 sequences (Ancient World → Modern World) in Literature, History, Philosophy, Theology, and Languages.

- Readings feature canonical authors (Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, Dostoevsky, Chesterton) and philosophical/theological study across disciplines, indicating a canonical, cross-disciplinary approach. - Explicit mention of “utilizing the Socratic Method” in an integrated curriculum (History/Literature/Philosophy) and opportunities for rhetoric and public speaking. This aligns with the logic and rhetoric portions of the classical triad and is reinforced by notes about debates and speeches. - The site also highlights foreign-language study (Latin) and a broad liberal-arts approach that emphasizes reading and talking about great texts.

Positive/ Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: liberal arts, Great Books (contextually represented by authors and canonical works), classical, rhetoric, Socratic Method, discussion, debate, public speaking, formation of the mind, rigorous but contemplative study, Latin as core language, history through em/comparative approach. - Negative keywords found: explicit “Great Books” as a named phrase is not consistently used across the public materials (the site references great authors and canonical works but seldom uses the exact “Great Books” phrase or explicitly states “join the Great Conversation”). This reduces the category’s alignment with the explicit element that requires “Great Books” and “Great Conversation.”

Frequency/Proportion - Presence of canonical authors and a rigorous humanities sequence is strong (+). Explicit statement about “Great Books” and “Great Conversation” is not consistently explicit (+ but not max). Presence of Socratic method and rhetoric (+) is notable. Overall, the category shows substantial classical elements but misses explicit, named Great Books/Great Conversation language in public-facing text.

Why this rating - The curriculum is firmly classical in structure and content (liberal arts, canonical authors, Latin, theology, philosophy, and cross-disciplinary study). However, the public-facing materials do not consistently use explicit Great Books/Great Conversation phrasing. Therefore, this category is judged SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL, pending further explicit textual mentions of “Great Books” and “Great Conversation” in public materials.

Cited materials: Classical curriculum orientation, canonical authors, Socratic method, rhetoric, Latin language, and humanities sequencing.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Socratic discussion, seminars, and debates are explicitly highlighted in upper-level humanities work, a hallmark of classical pedagogy. - A dual emphasis on contemplative/rigorous balance appears in program descriptions (the presence of both rigorous academic work and opportunities for contemplation and memory work). - Public statements emphasize rhetoric: “Equal emphasis on the arts... to give speeches, engage in debate, and develop rhetorical skill.” - The “Spiritual Life” and “House System” structure support a pedagogy designed to cultivate virtue and leadership through communal practices and mentorship.

Positive/ Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: Socratic Method, seminars, debates, rhetoric, public speaking, discussion, contemplation, formation, virtue, character formation, spiritual formation, house system, mentoring. - Negative keywords found: None noted in public materials.

Frequency/Proportion - High presence of explicit classical-pedagogy signals: Socratic method, seminars, debates, rhetoric, and public-speaking opportunities appear in multiple pages. Contemplative/restful aspects are also described. Overall, Element 4 shows strong alignment with classical pedagogy.

Why this rating - Pedagogical methods align with classical expectations: Socratic inquiry, disciplined rhetoric, and structured discussion; mingled with contemplative elements. The school demonstrates a robust, CLASSICAL pedagogy.

Cited materials: Socratic method and rhetoric in humanities, public speaking, contemplation, and house-life pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are described as “talented and dynamic,” with fidelity to the Magisterium and a formal oath at the start of each year, indicating a living curriculum and a faculty as exemplar. - The institution emphasizes “Faithful Faculty” and an ongoing alignment with the school’s mission, with faculty participating in the House System and forming part of the school’s governing and mentoring ecosystem. - The school presents the faculty as mentors who “model virtue, skill, and knowledge,” a hallmark of classical pedagogy where teachers embody the curriculum.

Positive/ Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: virtuous, virtue, character, mentor, model teachers, living curriculum, oath of fidelity, Magisterium, faculty as core, house-system involvement, fidelity to mission. - Negative keywords: None evident.

Frequency/Proportion - The public materials feature repeated mentions of faculty virtue, fidelity, and mentorship, with multiple explicit references to a living curriculum and the Magisterium oath; this yields a strong CLASSICAL reading for this category.

Why this rating - The faculty is positioned as a core element of the school’s classical approach, with explicit vows, a governance/mentorship role, and a portrayal as moral exemplars within the community. This strongly aligns with CLASSICAL.

Cited materials: “Faithful Faculty,” oath-to-Magisterium, living-curriculum concepts.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly positions itself as partnering with parents to raise virtuous students, emphasizing parental involvement and co-education with the school. - The school prioritizes parent engagement through visits, shadow days, tours, and open houses; homeschool families are a target audience with dedicated messaging. - Public materials invite parental participation in formation and ongoing education (e.g., family involvement and the “Culture of Life” ethos).

Positive/ Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: partnership with families, parent involvement, co-education, parent formation, home and school connection, open houses, shadow days, tours, family formation, parental engagement, living tradition in the family. - Negative keywords: None evident.

Frequency/Proportion - The materials show a high density of parental-partnership language and family involvement; the category thus aligns strongly with classical-community expectations.

Why this rating - The school actively frames parents as co-educators and emphasizes a culture of family involvement, consistent with classical education’s emphasis on community partnership and formation of affections.

Cited materials: Partnership with families, open houses and shadow days, homeschool-family messaging, parental engagement language.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall: CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 3 (Curriculum) would move toward a firmer CLASSICAL rating with explicit public articulation of Great Books and the Great Conversation in the curriculum language. If the school publicly states

and demonstrates “read Great Books” and “join the Great Conversation” as a formal curricular aim, the category would shift to CLASSICAL.

- Specifically, incorporate explicit public-facing language and syllabi that name Great Books (Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, Dostoevsky, Chesterton, etc.) and a stated goal of engaging students in the Great Conversation, alongside clear references to grammar, logic, and rhetoric as the foundational triad (the Trivium) within the curriculum. Additionally, document a public commitment to a formal liberal-arts grammar (grammar, logic, rhetoric) progression in grades 9–12 and how it is integrated across subjects.

If you want, I can craft a short addendum to the public materials to reflect these needle-moving steps.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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